

LinkedIn Posts from AI Fundraising Trends PPT

POST 1 — Seed to Series A Is Brutal Now

Only 15% of seed startups now make it to Series A.

In 2021, it was 40% ([Carta](#)).

Today? It's 15%.

What happened?

Startups need:

More traction

More revenue

A tighter story, all before they even have a full team.

It's not that VCs aren't writing checks.

They're just *way choosier* about who gets them.

This isn't a "build it and they'll come" market.

It's "build it, prove it, and make it feel inevitable."

If you're a founder struggling to raise... It's not just you.

The bar moved. And no one sent the memo.

According to [Carta](#) and [PitchBook](#):

- Average timeline from seed → A: now 30 months
- More bridge rounds labeled "Seed+", "Pre-A", or "C++"
- Only a narrow slice of startups are getting through the funnel

What's your path to Series A?

Are you navigating this shift?

POST 2 — Seed Math Is Broken (And VCs Know It)

Median post-money at seed in 2024? \$14.8M.

Seed-to-A conversion rate? 13%.

If you're a fund writing seed checks, you're betting:

- Your pick will grow like hell
- You'll "fix ownership" at Series A
- And you're better than the median

But here's the math:

- If you pay a \$15M seed valuation and only 13% of those go to Series A...
- You're effectively pricing those A-stage companies at \$115M risk-adjusted.

Median Series A valuation? \$56M.

So why are VCs still writing those seed checks?

Because they believe:

- ① Their portfolio will break out faster than others
- ② They'll double down on winners
- ③ Everyone else is wrong

Most won't make this math work.

But everyone thinks *they're* the exception.

POST 3 — ARR per FTE: The Metric That Matters

CAC is out.

Retention is expected.

Now? VCs want to know your ARR / FTE.

→ ARR = Annual Recurring Revenue

→ FTE = Full-Time Employee

→ ARR / FTE = Your team's real efficiency

[Craft Ventures](#) + [OpenVC](#) both point to this shift.

You're not just building software anymore.

You're building a revenue machine powered by lean teams + AI leverage.

Real examples:

- [Cursor](#) hit \$200M ARR with ~60 employees → \$3M+ per FTE ([Sacra](#))
- [Klarna](#) boosted ARR/FTE from \$575K → \$1M+
- [Copy.ai](#) runs with under 20 employees and has scaled across categories

If you're not tracking ARR/FTE, you're already behind.

What's your efficiency number?

POST 4 — Option Pools Are Shrinking. Fast.

Used to be 10–20% set aside for hires.

Now? Founders are reserving just 6–8%.

Why?

Because early-stage teams are:

- Smaller
- AI-augmented
- Hiring *way* later

In the early days, you didn't need 10 engineers.

You need one founder using ChatGPT, [Replit](#), and [Zapier](#) to move like a team of five.

[Carta](#) confirms this trend:

- ♦ Option pool sizes are down across the board
- ♦ Many founders are skipping hires entirely pre-A
- ♦ AI is replacing 2–3 early roles

Option pools aren't disappearing.

They're just evolving.

POST 5 — SF Still Runs the AI Table

Say what you want about the Bay Area...

But when it comes to AI capital, SF still runs the game.

[PitchBook](#) 2025 Geo Report:

- 50% of early-stage AI funding → SF
- 75% of late-stage AI dollars → SF

That \$50M Series A?

That massive AI infrastructure raise?

Odds are, it went to a founder pitching *from the Bay*.

Yes, the rent is wild.

Yes, the coffee is \$6, and you still tip.

But you get:

- Access
- Signal
- Rooms that get what you're building

Founders like [Runway](#), [Anthropic](#), and [OpenAI](#) didn't stay in SF because it's cute.

They stayed because this is where AI happens.

Are you still betting on SF?

POST 6 — Seed Rounds Are Now Just Bridges With Better Names

Half of the seed rounds aren't seed rounds anymore.

They're bridges, disguised with fancier names:

- Seed+
- Pre-A
- C++ (yes, that's real 🙄)

Why?

Because founders aren't scaling.

They're buying time to hit the traction investors used to ignore... and now *require*.

[SignalFire](#): 50%+ of early rounds are just extensions.

[Carta](#): Seed-to-A conversion dropped to 15%.

The market moved.

The milestones moved.

The goalposts? They're not even on the field anymore.

If you're explaining your entire existence just to raise an extra 6 months of runway, you're not crazy.

You're just early.

And "early-stage" isn't what it used to be.

POST 7 — The New Hiring Strategy: Don't Hire Yet

2022: First hire by month 3.

2025: First hire... maybe never?

Founders today are:

- Coding with Copilots
- Automating ops with [Zapier](#), [Notion](#), [ChatGPT](#)
- Closing deals solo, no SDRs, no assistant

It's not "do more with less."

It's doing more with fewer humans.

As @Roger Spitz says:

"AI won't replace humans, but people who can use AI will."

And this gem from @Stewart Butterfield:

"AI replaces mind-numbing behavior, not people."

[NEX](#): Teams are smaller, and hiring is later

[Carta](#): Option pools are shrinking because no one's hiring yet

This isn't about skipping people forever.

It's about surviving long enough to *deserve* them.

POST 8 — The Fundraising Timeline Is Breaking Down

Remember the 18–24 month cadence?

- Raise seed
- Build
- Raise Series A 18 months later

Yeah. That's dead.

Now:

- Some founders aren't raising again... because they can't
- Others aren't... because they *don't need to*

They stayed lean.

They became profitable.

Or they just stopped playing the VC game altogether.

Examples from [Carta](#) & [OpenView](#):

- More startups extending 30–36 months between raises
- More founders are skipping rounds or fundraising silently
- The rise of “angel + AI” teams skipping institutional capital

The old playbook never worked for most of us.

And now, we've got a new one.

POST 9 — This Is a Sniper Market

This market doesn't reward effort.

It rewards:

- Momentum
- Signal
- The perception of inevitability

Fewer startups are raising.

But the ones that are? They're raising big.

- ♦ Median AI seed: \$18M
- ♦ Median AI Series A: \$50M

(Source: a16z, [PitchBook](#), [Carta](#))

You're either "AI hot"...
Or waitlisted indefinitely.

If you're not in that top slice, it's rough.
If you *are*, the upside has *never* been better.

This isn't a spray-and-pray season.
It's a sniper market.

Build like you're in that tier, And back it up with traction they can't ignore.

POST 10 — Pricing Is Broken in the AI Era

AI doesn't log in.
It doesn't buy seats.
It just... delivers work.

So, if you're still charging per seat in 2025?
You're probably pricing it wrong.

Growth Unhinged + Forbes:

- Seat-based pricing fell from 21% → 15%
- Hybrid pricing jumped to 41%
- The rate is falling fast

Real startups shifting pricing:

- [Clay](#): hybrid credits + seats
- [Copy.ai](#): adaptive flat-rate
- [OpenAI](#): pure usage-based

AI changed what users look like.
Your pricing should reflect that.

Are you still pricing for people or performance?

POST 11 — Outcome-Based Pricing = The Holy Grail

Everyone talks about pricing for impact.

But here's the truth:

Only 5% of SaaS companies price based on outcomes.

By 2028? That might hit 25%.

Why so hard?

You need CAMP:

- ✓ Consistency
- ✓ Attribution
- ✓ Measurability
- ✓ Predictability

But early movers are already shipping it:

- [AirHelp](#) — 35% success fee
- [Chargeflow](#) — % of chargebacks recovered
- [EvenUp](#) — legal AI: per case outcomes
- [Flycode](#) — DevOps with results-driven pricing

Pricing for *value*, not usage, is tough.

But it's where this is headed.

Could you price your product based on outcomes?

POST 12 — Pick Your Hybrid Pricing Flavor

Hybrid pricing isn't one-size-fits-all.

There are 7 core flavors:

- ♦ PAYG — [OpenAI](#)
- ♦ PAYG with cap — [Postmark](#)
- ♦ Usage tiers — [Snyk](#) & [Zapier](#)
- ♦ Platform fee + usage — [Retool](#)
- ♦ Platform + included usage + overages — [Notion](#)
- ♦ Adaptive flat rate — [Copy.ai](#)
- ♦ Platform fee + success bonus — [AssemblyAI](#)

Hybrid pricing jumped to 41% adoption in 2025

The trick?

Pick the right structure for your stage, your AI usage, and your buyer.

Which hybrid model are you using?

POST 13 — Transparent Pricing: Not What It Seems

“Everyone should show their pricing!”

Yeah... until you're charging >\$5K ACV with usage tiers and AI credits.

Transparency sounds good.

But real pricing clarity? That's harder.

Growth Unhinged says:

- PLG companies: often transparent
- AI startups: rarely
- Complex deals: rarely

Real-world examples:

✓ [Linear](#) — crystal clear pricing

✗ [Anthropic](#)

✗ [OpenAI](#)

✗ [Runway](#)

They all charge, but few publish their model.

Buyers want clarity.

That doesn't always mean a public pricing page.

What's your transparency strategy?

POST 14 — Who Owns Pricing?

At \$1M ARR: Founder.

At \$10M ARR: Chaos.

Sales → Product → Finance → Ops → 🧑‍💻

Growth Unhinged:

- 75% of SaaS companies changed pricing in the past year
- Very few have a dedicated pricing lead
- Most still rely on spreadsheets and gut instinct

Real talk:

- [Jasper](#) started founder-led → now growth team
- [Ramp](#) has a dedicated monetization squad
- [Amplitude](#) reviews pricing quarterly with the product

Pricing is a strategy.

But we're still treating it like an afterthought.

Who owns pricing in your org?

POST 15 — Software Ownership → Outcomes: The Shift Is On

The monetization evolution:

- 1 On-prem: Buy it (e.g., [Oracle](#))
- 2 SaaS: Rent it (e.g., [HubSpot](#))
- 3 Usage-based: Pay as you go (e.g., [Snowflake](#), [Twilio](#))
- 4 Outcome-based: Pay for results (e.g., [EvenUp](#), [Chargeflow](#))

Every shift:

- Moves risk from buyer → vendor
- Demands new pricing muscles
- Changes how value is defined

You're not just delivering features anymore.

You're being paid for what happens.

Which phase is your pricing in?